MOREH NEVUCHIM

Hewn From the Rock: Sur, Avraham's Character & the Path to God's Glory

Given Tuesday 1 September 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:16

Sefer: Moreh Nevuchim (Rambam), Chelek Aleph — Rabbi Chaim Makbili's Hebrew edition / Sefaria

Chapter: I:16 — the term **tzur** (צור), preceded by a full review of the Introductions and Chapters 1–15

Date: Tuesday 1 September 2026 · 19 Elul 5786 — first shiur of the new term, a week and a half before Rosh Hashanah (very early this year)

Topic: Where we stand in the Moreh; the four meanings of *tzur*; *tzur* as origin/source — of Avraham and Sarah, and of God; the completed reading of **ויאמר ה' הנה מקום אתי ונצבת על הצור**

Schedule note: The series began after Pesach; the summer term covered the Introductions and **Chapters 1–15** — just under a quarter of Section 1 (which has some 79 chapters). This term runs **through to the end of December**, with breaks for Sukkot and Chol HaMoed — though the chagim fall nicely on the weekend this year, so momentum should hold. **No shiur next week**; the next Moreh shiur is **Tuesday 4 Tishrei**, the day after Tzom Gedaliah, in Aseret Yemei Teshuvah. Monday night HaMaspik continues; Thursday to be decided. **Chapter 17 was intended for tonight but was not reached** — it will open the learning in the new year, 5787.

Part One — Review of the Introductions

The Rambam himself instructed us to review constantly, so before opening new material we run the full framework again. (Thank you to those who took part in the summer revision questions — the aim was precisely to encourage chazarah.)

The Letter to Rabbi Yosef

The Moreh opens with the Rambam's **letter to his student Rabbi Yosef**, of whom he was very fond and who had left him. His stated purpose: to write essays **explaining multi-meaning terms in Tanach** that are open to different interpretations — many of which we have now seen across the first 15 chapters — and to **clarify veiled matters** in the Torah.

Who the Book Is For

The next introduction states that the book is **only for one educated in both Torah and philosophy** — someone caught between the verses of Tanach and tradition on the one hand and philosophy on the other, who is constantly **nevoch**, perplexed, unwilling to neglect either his intellect or his tradition, and seeking a way to hold them together. (The Rabbi's aside: by that

standard he himself, giving the shiur, does not qualify — yet the Rambam also says many people can benefit from the book, which is why we learn it together.)

Why It Cannot Be Exhaustive

The Rambam will **not explain everything exhaustively** — it isn't possible, and moreover:

- **Ma'aseh Merkavah** = the study of philosophy and theology
- **Ma'aseh Bereishit** = the study of the building blocks and first principles of science and existence

The Chachamim already ruled that these may not be expanded upon in a public setting, so the Rambam gives only **rashei perakim** — chapter headings. *(This is the subject of Chapter 17, coming next.)*

The more one develops one's character and intellect, the more **zohar** — shine — one draws from the book.

The Order of Learning

Science → theology → God. This is why the Torah begins with **Bereishit**: the first principles of existence come first, because you must understand the natural world in order to understand HaKadosh Baruch Hu.

A beautiful juxtaposition — on Simchat Torah (only weeks away) we move from the **death of Moshe**, greatest of all humans and greatest of prophets, straight back to **Bereishit**: you need first principles to understand HaKadosh Baruch Hu and to reach the levels of prophecy.

Meshalim and Final Advice

The Rambam distinguishes **kinds of allegory**: some meshalim where **every word** carries significance, and others where only the **general concept** is intended.

His concluding advice: **read the book many times, compare the chapters**, and **judge him favourably** where something appears surprising — don't jump on him.

The Seven Reasons for Contradictions

His final introduction gives **seven reasons** why contradictions appear in any book. The two that matter for us are **reasons five and seven** — including cases where the **Rambam has deliberately contradicted himself**. We will meet examples.

Part Two — Review of Chapters 1–15

Ch	Term / Subject	Core teaching
1	**Tzelem u-demut**	God is incorporeal (the philosophical proof comes much later). *Tzelem Elokim* is not physical form but **tzurah** — the intellect. In that respect the human is most *domeh* to God. **To'ar** is the word for purely physical form (ויהי יוסף יפה תואר ויפה מראה).
2	**Before and after the sin**	Adam already had the intellect — no one gets *rewarded* with more intellect for sinning. What changed: perception shifted from **emet ve-sheker**, objective intellectual truth, to **tov ve-ra**, subjective judgements shaped by culture, emotion and desire. The sin was a turn toward the sensual and the subjective — appearance over intellectual truth — and *middah ke-neged middah*, reality became blurred. The snake's והייתם כאלוקים ידעי טוב ורע has **nothing to do with God**: *Elokim* = **judges**, who must make arbitrary determinations between good and bad.
3	**Tavnit u-temunah**	**Tavnit** is always physical — never used of God in Tanach (תבנית המשכן ואת תבנית כל כליו). **Temunah** can be physical, but can also mean the **true essence** of a thing — and with God it always carries that latter meaning.
4	**Ra'ah · Hibbit · Chazah**	Three verbs of seeing: *ra'ah* = to look; *hibbit* = to gaze, to stare; *chazah* = to uncover, to penetrate to the depths. All three can be physical — but with HaKadosh Baruch Hu they always denote **intellectual** sight.
5	**Caution**	The burning bush, with four readings: (1) God was literally in the bush — **heretical**; (2) a created **Kevod Hashem**, a physical manifestation — acceptable (Rav Se'adyah) but not the Rambam's view; (3) entirely a prophetic vision; (4) **Moshe held back** — the whole episode is a metaphor for **caution** on entering the divine realm. Go slowly, gradually, refining yourself through logic and intellectual study — unlike those who rush. *(Hence the Rabbi's own approach: better to go slowly and review than to cover more ground.)*
6	**Ish ve-ishah**	Borrowed terms beyond male and female: **ish** = that which attaches itself; **ishah** = the receptacle that receives. All of existence reduces to attacher and attached — philosophically **tzurah** and **chomer**. **Essential for Chapter 17 — go back over Chapter 6.**
7	**Yalad**	Continues Chapter 6: the offspring of *ish ve-ishah*. To give birth physically, but also to **produce novel thoughts, views and teachings** in another. For 130 years Adam could not "birth" properly in *tzelem Elokim* because of the sin, producing incomplete humans — which is all the Chachamim mean by **shedim**. Hence a rav is said to be *molid* his talmid.
8	**Makom**	Geographical place; or **status/rank** (ממלא מקומו); or a **conceptual, intellectual position** — as in English, "I'm in a bad place." Hence ברוך כבוד ה' ממקומו — and **הנה מקום אתי**, needed for tonight.
9	**Kisei**	A physical chair; or something **majestic** (shamayim, the Mikdash); or **God Himself** — as in כי יד על כס יה in Beshalach.
10	**Alah ve-yarad**	Literal ascent/descent; levels of holiness; or **the directing of attention**. With people: up toward the lofty and holy, down to the mundane — the prophet ascends, then divests himself of prophecy to come down and teach. With God it is always attention: **yarad** =

		resting the Shechinah and imparting prophecy (or punishing); **alah** = the prophecy has concluded.
11	**Yashav**	To sit → **stability, permanence, continuity**. With Hashem: completely unchanging. Hashem does not sit in heaven any more than anywhere else — He is everywhere and nowhere — but the verses locate His "sitting" in heaven because in Aristotle's and the Rambam's cosmology the **heavens are the most enduring and unchanging** thing there is.
12	**Kam**	Physically rising, or establishing something — but with Hashem always **executing judgment** or **fulfilling a promise** (תקום תרחם ציון: either judgment on Tzion's enemies or fulfilment of the promise to rebuild her).
13	**Amidah**	Physical standing; stopping; and third — **permanence**. With Hashem always the third: continuance and permanence.
14	**Adam**	The first human; humanity as a whole; or the **ordinary person** in contradistinction to the **ish**, the elevated one. We are all *Adam*, all belonging to the material — but we have the capacity to become *ish*.
15	**Nitzav**	Like *yashav*, in the sense of **permanence and stability**. With God it means His eternal, unchanging nature — and with it the Rambam re-read the whole episode of **Yaakov's ladder**: והנה מלאכי אלהים עלים וירדים בו והנה ה' נצב עליו.

The shape of the fifteen chapters: a great deal of time on **verbs of posture** — *yashav*, *kam*, *amidah*, *nitzav*, *alah*, *yarad* — alongside **types of human being** — *ish*, *ishah*, *adam* — and the foundational concepts. Chapter 16 now **completes the unit** of *makom*, *nitzav* and *tzur* — it all comes together — and **Chapter 17 begins something entirely different**.

Part Three — Chapter 16: צור (Tzur)

The Verse Behind the Chapter

After the sin of the golden calf, Moshe says:

הראני נא את כבדך — Show me Your glory.

Hashem answers that no person can see His face and live, and then:

ויאמר ה' הנה מקום אתי ונצבת על הצור

"There is a place with Me, and you shall stand on the rock."

Two of the three key words we already have:

מקום (Chapter 8) — a **conceptual place**. You asked to see My glory; I cannot give you everything, I cannot show My face — but there is a **conceptual place**, an intellectual ascent, that I *can* give you.

ונצבת (Chapter 15) — this cannot be physical standing. Even though the verse speaks of a human being, he is being addressed **in relation to Hashem** — and He is *commanding* him to stand, so it must mean something more. It means **permanence**: *be permanently al hatzur*.

What remains is the last piece of the jigsaw: **what is the tzur?** And alongside the definition, the Rambam will draw a **mussar** lesson about how we ought to live.

The Four Meanings of Tzur

צור מונח רב משמעותי — *tzur* is a multi-meaning term.

1. A boulder — a great mountainous rock

שם ההר as in — **והכית בצור ויצאו ממנו מים ושתה העם**

The English editions render this as "mountain," but the Rabbi's own reading is that it means something more like a **boulder** — a very large rock. Why does the Rambam take it beyond an ordinary rock? Likely because of **הנני עמד לפניך שם על הצור בחרב** — the *tzur* is associated with **Chorev**, with the mountain, so he understands it as a piece of the mountain. **It would be wrong to call a big rock in the street a *tzur*** — it would have to be boulder-like.

2. A hard, sharp stone — flint

הוא שם האבן הקשה כחלמיש — as in **עשה לך חרבות צרים ושוב מל את בני ישראל שנית**

Hashem tells Yehoshua to circumcise Bnei Yisrael again — with **charvot tzurim**, sharp flint knives. Obviously you cannot circumcise with a boulder; here *tzur* must be **flintstone**.

3. A quarry — the rock-face stones are hewn from

והוא שם המכרה שכורים ממנו אבני מחצב — as in **הביטו אל צור חצבתם**

The verse in Yeshayahu (51):

שמעו אלי רדפי צדק מבקשי ה'... הביטו אל צור חצבתם ואל מקבת בור נקרתם

"Listen to Me, you who pursue justice... **look to the rock you were hewn from**, and to the pit you were quarried out of."

A great quarry from which stone is cut — that is a *tzur*.

Note that all three meanings so far are entirely physical and material.

4. (Borrowed) The origin and source of anything

אחר כך הושאל מונח זה מן המשמעות האחרונה למשמעות של מוצא ושורש

From the third meaning — the quarry — the term was **borrowed** to mean the **origin, source and root** of a thing. And this is proved from the continuation of that very verse in Yeshayahu:

הביטו אל אברהם אביכם ואל שרה תחוללכם כי אחד קראתיו ואברכהו וארבהו

כאילו פירש שהצור שחצבתם ממנו הוא אברהם אביכם — as if to say explicitly: the quarry you were hewn from. **ועל כן לכו בעקבותיו והנהגו על פי דתו והדמו למידותיו** — therefore walk in his footsteps, follow his way, and make yourselves resemble him **in his character traits**, **כי טבע המכרה חייב להימצא במה שנחצב ממנו** — because the nature of the quarry must be found in whatever is hewn from it. (In English: *a chip off the block* — the chip should be true to the block.)

Note carefully: this fourth meaning is still not about God. At this stage it is purely the idea of **going back to the origins** of something.

Habitu el Tzur — the Spiritual Quarry

So הביטו אל צור חצבתם means: **look at where you came from — Avraham and Sarah — and be like them.** Clearly this is not a genetic point but a matter of **character and path**.

The Rambam's letter to Rabbi Ovadiah the Ger

We learned this letter together just under a year ago (in the winter term). Ovadiah the convert asked: **may I say אלוקינו ואלוקי אבותינו — "our God and the God of our fathers" — when Avraham is not my father?** The Rambam replied: he is **not your genetic father, but he is your spiritual father**, and that is what "father" means here — so yes, you say it. **This became the halacha**, even though it is far from obvious: it appears the **Yerushalmi** held this way and the **Bavli** did not, and the Rambam seems to follow the Yerushalmi. His whole point: the **true father is the one whose character you take on**.

The end of Hilchot Avadim — the Rambam's own application

מותר לעבוד בעבד כנעני בפרך — one is permitted, by strict law, to work a Canaanite slave harshly.

ואף על פי שהדין כך, מדת חסידות ודרכי חכמה שיהיה אדם רחמן ורודף צדק ולא יכביד עולו על עבדו ולא יצר לו

Even though the *din* permits it, that is not how good people behave — feed him first, don't shout at him, don't be harsh with him. And note **who is saying this**: the same Rambam who counts **לעולם בהם תעבדו** among the 613 mitzvot — a mitzvah *not* to free an eved Kena'ani (a machloket Rishonim, but assume the Rambam's view). And still:

> **ואין האכזריות והעזות מצויה אלא בעכו"ם עובדי עבודה זרה. אבל זרעו של אברהם אבינו, והם ישראל שהשפיע להם הקדוש ברוך הוא טובת התורה וציוום בחוקים ומשפטים צדיקים — רחמנים הם על הכל**

Cruelty is found among idolaters; but the **seed of Avraham** — Israel, upon whom Hashem bestowed the goodness of the Torah — **are merciful to all**. Not merely genetic descent: you are the **spiritual children of Avraham**, and that is how Avraham behaves. **That is הביטו אל צור חצבתם in practice.**

Hashem as Tzur

ולפי המשמעות האחרונה הזאת נקרא השם יתעלה צור

Only in this fourth sense — origin, source, quarry — is Hashem called *tzur*.

כי הוא הראשית והסיבה הפועלת לכל מה שזולתו

He is the **beginning** and the **active cause** of everything besides Himself.

Note the word **הפועלת** — *active*, ongoing. It is a fundamental principle of our belief that Hashem is **constantly** engaged with this world and constantly sustaining it, giving existence at every moment.

The Tzur Verses

*(Timely: **Ha'azinu**, where the word appears repeatedly, is read on Shabbat Shuvah, the Shabbat after Rosh Hashanah — next week's parashah being Nitzavim-Vayeilech.)*

הצור תמים פעלו כי כל דרכיו משפט

Every rabbi has this verse on his lips too often — it is said at **Tzidduk HaDin**, at every funeral, every stone-setting, every shivah. **Why this verse when someone dies?** Because at exactly the moment when a person is confused and cannot see Hashem in his life, we affirm: **You are the Tzur, the source of all existence — even of the things that are not good.** Yes, it is painful, and

we cannot fathom why it happened; but it came from You, the origin of everything. **That itself is the nechamah.**

צור ילדך תשי ותשכח אל מחללך

You grew forgetful of the Rock that bore you — you forgot your **origin**, the One who gave birth to you. Like parents who gave you everything and are cast aside: they are your origins, you came into this world through them, and you discard them.

אם לא כי צורם מכרם וה' הסגירם

How can enemies pursue and defeat us with so much smaller a force? It must be that **their Rock — their origin — handed them over**.

אין קדוש כה' כי אין בלתך ואין צור כאלהינו

Chanah, after the birth of Shmuel. Why does she reach for the word *tzur*? Because she had all but given up — and now declares: **You are the source of all existence; it all came from You in the end.**

The Gemara in Berachot's wordplay: read not *ein tzur* but **אין צייר כאלוקינו** — there is no **artist** like our God. And what is an artist? **The source of the painting.** Put paint in front of you or me and we make a mess; the artist is the origin — he can do whatever he wishes, he gives the painting its very nature by how he joins the colours. *Tzur* and *tzayar* sit together beautifully: as Hashem is the Rock, the origin of all, so the artist is the origin of any painting. Perhaps that is exactly why the Chachamim made the play here.

בטחו בה' עדי עד כי ביה ה' צור עולמים

Trust in Hashem forever, for in Him is the **Rock of worlds**. Why should you have bitachon? **Because He is the origin of everything** — so what is there to worry about? Those at the Monday night HaMaspik shiurim will recall that we **finished the levels of bitachon at the end of last term in July**, and that **Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam identifies this very pasuk as the highest level** — where you are entirely confident that everything comes from Hashem. Now we see *why* it is the highest: because you recognise that **everything originates in Him — He is the Tzur, the quarry**.

The Verse Completed — ונצבת על הצור

הישען והתמד על בחינת היותו של השם יתעלה ראשית כל מציאות

Lean upon, and be constant in, the contemplation that Hashem is the **origin of all existence** — for this is the path by which you reach Him.

One verse; three chapters; a completely transformed reading:

Word	Chapter	Meaning
מקום	8	A conceptual, intellectual place/rank — not a location
ונצבת	15	Permanence — constantly, firmly
הצור	16	The origin and source of all existence

therefore means: **contemplate the Source of all existence firmly and ונצבת על הצור**
you will reach that place — **הנה מקום אתי** — **constantly.** And when you do that.

Look how it answers Moshe. He asked **הראני נא את כבדך**. Hashem replies, in effect: *yes, I am willing to show you My glory — but you must do your part.* **I cannot show you Myself; I can show you My creation, and through it you can come to understand Me.** So stand permanently on the rock — be constantly turned toward the origins of everything — and by that you will reach and grasp My glory.

The Same Idea in Mishneh Torah

This is precisely **Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah 2:2**, after Chapter 1's treatment of God's unity and incorporeality. How do we fulfil the mitzvah to love Hashem?

בשעה שיתבונן האדם במעשיו וברואיו הנפלאים הגדולים ויראה מהן חכמתו שאין לה ערך ולא קץ — מיד הוא אוהב ומשבח ומפאר ומתאווה תאווה גדולה לידע השם הגדול

When you contemplate His works and creations and see in them wisdom without measure or limit, **love follows immediately**. And therefore, says the Rambam, I will now explain to you the first principles of science — so that you can understand Hashem. **Yesodei HaTorah 2:2 is the fulfilment of ונצבת על הצור.**

So when we read Parshat Ki Tisa, the verse now reads: there is a **makom** — a status, a place of intellectual comprehension of Me — and the way you attain it is **ונצבת על הצור**, by constantly standing on, contemplating and developing your grasp of the **Tzur**: the quarry, the origin, the beginning of all, the Painter and Artist of everything, HaKadosh Baruch Hu Himself. Do that, and you will find the *makom*. **Stunning.**

Closing Points

Ma'oz Tzur Yeshuati

Now think about the Chanukah piyut: **מעוז צור ישועתי, לך נאה לשבח**. Why address HaKadosh Baruch Hu specifically as *Ma'oz* and *Tzur*? Because the piyut runs through every persecution — Greeks, Romans, Persians, Haman — and declares: through all of it, **You are unchanging; more than that, You are the stronghold and the Rock, the origin of all**. We recognise that even the terrible things trace back to You.

The Chapter's Double Achievement

1. **Removing incorporeality** — where the verse uses *tzur* of Hashem it means nothing physical whatsoever; and it completes the reading of *makom* and *nitzav*.
2. **A moral teaching** — the **intellectual apprehension of Hashem** on the one hand, and the **ethical character of Avraham and Sarah** on the other. We have a duty toward **both**.

A Final, Deliberately Pointed Note

Return to **הביטו אל צור חצבתם**. Could one not read the "quarry you were hewn from" as **God Himself**, given that *tzur* elsewhere does refer to Hashem (הצור תמים פעלו)? **Notice that the Rambam pointedly does not use Yeshayahu 51 among his God-verses.**

The straightforward answer is that the next verse says explicitly *Avraham and Sarah*. But there is more to it. **This kind of reading is commonly heard today and the Rabbi considers it outright**

heretical.

His own experience: his daughter came home from school in Year 1 with a vocabulary list — *adam* = man, and **neshamah** translated as *"a piece of Hashem inside us."* What does a Year 1 child understand by "soul"? He phoned the school immediately: what do you mean, a piece of Hashem?! This idea — that there is a little piece of Hashem within us — **is heard a great deal in Chabad**, and it is very likely **precisely why the Rambam avoided that verse**: so that no one should read הביטו אל צור חצבתם as though we were **hewn out of God**.

We are not. There is no piece of Hashem within us. There is no such concept in the Rambam's thought. We should not think in these terms, should not teach our children these things, and when we hear them we should call them out. Perhaps the Ba'al HaTanya held that way — but it is not our derech.

Summary — Chapter 16

Tzur has four meanings: a **boulder** (והכית בצור), a **flint** (חרבות צרים), a **quarry** (הביטו אל צור חצבתם), and — borrowed from the third — the **origin and source** of a thing. In that fourth sense the verse in Yeshayahu identifies the quarry as **Avraham and Sarah**: look to your spiritual origin and take on their character, for the nature of the quarry must be found in what is hewn from it. **In that same fourth sense alone** is Hashem called *Tzur* — **הראשית והסיבה הפועלת לכל מה שזולתו**, the beginning and the constantly active cause of all that is besides Him. Hence the Ha'azinu verses, Chanah's אין צור כאלוקינו (and the Gemara's אין צייר), and the highest level of bitachon, כי ביה ה' צור עולמים. And hence the completed verse: **הנה מקום אתי ונצבת על הצור** — the intellectual *makom* is attained by **constant contemplation of the Source of all existence**, exactly as the Rambam prescribes in Yesodei HaTorah 2:2. The chapter both strips away corporeality and delivers a **dual mussar**: intellectual apprehension of God, and the ethical character of Avraham.

Coming Up

- **Chapter 17** — not reached tonight. Here the Rambam **goes completely off-track** again: a very short chapter (two or three paragraphs) on the **concealment of esoteric teachings**, after which he returns to terms. Why he does this, and what he is teaching, next time. **Chapter 6 (ish ve-ishah) is essential background — please review it**, because Chapter 17 cannot be understood without it.
- **No shiur next week.** Next Moreh shiur **Tuesday 4 Tishrei**, the day after Tzom Gedaliah, during Aseret Yemei Teshuvah — b'ezrat Hashem beginning Chapter 17 in the new year **5787**.
- Monday night **HaMaspik** continues; Thursday to be confirmed.

תזכו לשנים רבות וטובות — the Rabbi's berachah to all.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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